that my staff knew that I did not belong to the prison cadre and that they had to bear with me only till such time as I was posted here. In the Delhi Police the situation is very different, because there they know that we could be working together on posting after posting. In Tihar most of the staff members were not even from the prison cadre and they knew that our association may not last for very long. Another inhibiting factor was that they were not used to serving under a woman officer and therefore felt they could not communicate with me as they would with a man. I was aware of these things and I had to face them.

The prison cadre is non-transferable, and so I could not use the threat of transfer for disciplinary purposes. I was short on staff and I needed whatever staff I had. I had to convert them to a positive line of thinking. The staff I had was by and large inadequately trained; some of them even had no training at all, they were close minded, habituated to an earlier regime of repression and force, and quite a number of them were much older to me. The plus side was that they immediately understood that I was a no-nonsense person, that I would not indulge in dishonest means and that I would never sanction force and beatings.

The jail superintendents had, for long, kowtowed to the junior staff because they did not have the backing of their own superiors and also because the junior staff had been here for a very long period. Whatever the superintendents had to do had to be got done by the lower staff and therefore they had to make a lot of compromises. Because of individualized functioning a lot was happening that should not have been allowed at all. But then, they were working within their limitations. The problem itself was clear to see. The lower staff did what they liked or could because the superintendents had no control over them. This was because the superintendents had no backing from their senior staff. Headquarters had distanced itself from the prison and no one from there would even bother to make visits. So, if they could not understand the prisoners' and the prison's problems they could not offer any solutions and, therefore, they also became a part of the problem. It was apparent that no one wanted to even try and do anything because they were overawed by the enormity of the problem and had a defeatist attitude right from the word go. No efforts were made in trying to build up a team, and it is only a team that can work collectively, and collective effort was the need of the hour.

I knew that the staff used to resort to beating, abusing, corruption, unreasonableness and insensitivity. But this was from hearsay and it would have gone against me if I had accused them on that basis. It was only when situations exposed such actions that I would confront them with the reality and point out what was wrong and what should, or could, have been done. Sometimes the staff would tell me that if they had not resorted to beatings then the prisoners would have caught them by the throat. I told them that what they meant was that they did not have enough security. The solution lay in providing more security and not in beating. In this way I would be tackling the staff, and their problems, on a one-to-one basis. That fostered confidence in them and they became willing to go by my suggestions. I realized that this one-to-one basis was sending better signals to the staff than any theoretical lecture would have done. Sometimes the staff would come up and tell me that all these prisoners were thieves and criminals and that they only deserved what they were getting. I had to be very patient and explain to them that they had no business to decide on matters that were not within their scope of duties. They were only supposed to be the custodians and bodyguards of the prisoners. Their job was only to look after the security and well-being of these prisoners under their charge. They should therefore set for themselves clear-cut parameters of work and not go beyond them in judging prisoners' characters or condemning their alleged guilt. They could not become the judge.